00 · META

Chalk Book Guide

Purpose, structure & conventions

A personal technical chalk book. After a session of problem-solving, building or learning with an AI, the work is distilled into one calm, skimmable note that can be revisited later for a fast refresher, on a small local site or as a PDF.

This is the read-only copy of `CLAUDE.md`, which is the source of truth.

Local — your machine | Remote — the server | Config file | Concept | AWS Console | Gotcha | Best practice | Paths

Purpose

- ✓ **Capture** recent work while it is fresh: commands, configs, decisions, mistakes.
- ✓ **Revisit** it later and get the gist in under a minute.
- ✓ **Repeat** it cold, months later, without re-researching anything.
- ✓ **Trace** what was done, per project and date, so a future AI can recall which scenarios have been worked through.

Two kinds of knowledge

Recurring

Used again and again: `systemctl`, ssh config, naming rules.

The note is a fast reference. Patterns, quick tables, the one flag you always forget.

One-off

Set up once, or a rare fix: growing an EBS volume, a logrotate permission error.

The note is a complete recipe. Every step in order, every flag explained, so it can be redone from zero.

Best practice · When in doubt, write for the forgetful future self. Assume nothing is remembered.

The collection

```
chalk-book/
├── CLAUDE.md                    # this guide (source of truth)
├── 00-chalk-book-guide.pdf      # read-only copy of this guide
├── chalk-pastel.css             # the note colour palette (user-owned)
├── index.html                   # the site: open it in a browser
├── site/                        # catalogue (notes.js), menu, search, dark theme
├── notes/                       # one HTML file per note
│   ├── tinker-town-01-aws-ssh-firewall.html …
│   ├── note-layout.css          # shared layout and components
│   └── fonts/                   # bundled Inter, renders offline
├── archive/                     # original PDFs from before the HTML rebuild
└── .claude/skills/memory-dump/  # the note-making workflow
```

File naming

```
<project>-<NN>-<topic>.html
```

PART	RULE	EXAMPLE
project	Slug from the project list, so the name says where the work happened.	`tinker-town`
NN	Two digits, counting up within each project.	`03`
topic	2–4 words naming the subject, not the outcome.	`cron-logrotate`
scope	One topic per file. A long session becomes several notes.	—
date	Inside the note and in `site/notes.js`, not in the file name.	`2026-08-30`
00-	Reserved for meta files about the chalk book itself.	`00-chalk-book-guide`

Projects

SLUG	DISPLAY NAME	WHAT IT IS
`tinker-town`	Project Tinker Town	Self-paced AWS Linux sysadmin lab, a one-week crash course in 7 modules
`pokedex`	Pokédex	The Pokédex web project
`meta`	Chalk Book	Notes about the chalk book itself

A new project gets a row here and in `CHALK_PROJECTS` in `site/notes.js`, which can also hold its roadmap of modules.

Note types

Walkthrough
What was done in a session, start to finish. Most notes are this type.

Reference
A cross-cutting rulebook other notes depend on, such as naming conventions. It says so in its summary.

Anatomy of a note

Every note follows the same top-to-bottom shape, so the eye always knows where to look.

1. **Header band**: eyebrow chip `PROJECT TINKER TOWN · 03 · MODULE 1 · 2026-08-30`, title words coloured blue, pink, green, yellow in turn, a short subtitle, and a 1–2 sentence past-tense summary.
2. **Legend**: colour chips for every block type used in the note.
3. **What we covered**: a ✓ checklist of outcomes, skimmable on its own.
4. **Full command sequence**: steps under short headings, each tagged Local or Remote
5. **Supporting sections**: concepts, diagrams, field tables, quick-reference tables.
6. **Bugs hit & fixed**: one card per real error, **Cause → Fix**.
7. **Where things live** and **Best practices** (short cards) as needed.
8. **Part of** line: the project, with links to related notes through the site.
9. **Footer** on printed pages: `Tinker Town 03 — Systemd Service · 1 / 3`

Block types

BLOCK	PALETTE COLOUR	USED FOR
Local	`--sky`	Commands run on your own machine
Remote	`--lav`	Commands run on the server
Config file	`--butter`	File contents, with the path as the block title
Concept	`--peri`	The *why* behind something; command output
Gotcha	`--peach`	Traps that bit, or nearly did; bug cards
Best practice	`--mint`	The recommended way, and why
Paths	`--pink`	File and folder locations; tables; title accent
AWS Console	`--coral`	Steps done in a web console, not a shell

Inline callouts use a bold label and a dot: **Gotcha ·** **Concept ·** **Key rule ·** **Naming note ·** **Updated rule ·**

Writing style

- ✓ **Skim first.** Headings, checklists and tables carry the story; prose only fills gaps.
- ✓ **Short.** Sentences under ~20 words. No intro paragraphs, no filler.
- ✓ **Every command gets a comment** explaining what it does and what each flag means.
- ✓ **Config files stay clean.** Annotations sit beside the file or in a field table, never inside it.
- ✓ **Real by default, except access, location and private life.** Actual commands, paths and error messages, but: no keys, passwords or tokens; placeholders such as `<instance-ip>` for public IPs, account IDs and emails; nothing about the user's private life. A username built from the user's name becomes `adm-<fruit>` (the lab's is `adm-kiwi`).
- ✓ **Keep the mistakes.** Errors and their fixes are often the most valuable part.
- ✓ **Respect history.** When a convention changes, mark old names as legacy instead of rewriting earlier notes.
- ✓ **Calm tone.** Plain, friendly and factual. No hype, no emoji.

```
sudo mkdir -p /mnt/data    # -p: create parents, no error if it exists
```

Gotcha · Many config formats break on inline comments. That is why config blocks are never annotated inside the block itself.

Visual style

Key rule · `chalk-pastel.css` is the palette for every note, until the user says otherwise. Colours are used only through its variables, never as hex values. The file belongs to the user.

How the palette is built

PART	EXAMPLE	USED FOR
chalk	`--lav`	Chips, borders, left bars
-bg	`--lav-bg`	Box tints
-ink	`--lav-ink`	Coloured text, comments
-chip	`--lav-chip`	Text on a chalk chip

Concept · Notes link the palette instead of copying it. Changing `chalk-pastel.css` restyles every note at its next render; PDFs keep their look until re-rendered.

Layout lives in `notes/note-layout.css`: A4 on `--paper`, an `--asphalt` header band, Inter for text, DejaVu Sans Mono for code, soft tinted blocks with a coloured left bar.

The site

- ✓ `index.html` opens straight from disk, no build step. Each note shows as a pastel A4 sheet in a dark frame in the warm greys of Claude's dark mode (`site/site-theme.css`, kept apart from the note palette).
- ✓ Left menu: search on top, then notes per project with roadmap progress and planned modules. The ☰ button (three chalk sticks) collapses it to a rail of note numbers and colour bars, with a chalk-stick tile for search.
- ✓ Search reads the full text of every note; results replace the list while typing, each note once with its hit count, and opening one highlights every hit. Rebuild the index with `node site/build-index.mjs`.
- ✓ The persistent main footer links Home, Backlog and Complete Tasks (private pages in `.prog/`, never committed) and Contact.
- ✓ Right panel: recently viewed notes, newest first. The name is one shared element, `<chalk-wordmark>`.
- ✓ **Export** opens a small menu; for now it holds **Save as PDF**, which opens the browser's print dialog for the open note.
- ✓ The menu starts as a rail; the menu button opens and closes it. Recently viewed is a rail too, sliding open over the note in 0.3 s while hovered and closing as soon as the cursor leaves.

How notes are made & changed

Concept · The notes are **read-only by design**. Nobody edits a note in a viewer; every change goes through an AI session.

Adding a note: the memory-dump skill

1. Work on something, in any project folder.
2. While it is fresh, say **“memory-dump”** or **“chalk that up”**. A personal pointer skill makes this work in every folder. An AI may also offer a dump when the topic changes or about an hour of content has built up.
3. The skill plans the notes, fills the template in `notes/`, adds them to `site/notes.js`, rebuilds the search index, checks every page, then commits and offers to push.
4. Check the note on the site and ask for any changes in the same session.

Changing a note or this guide

- ✓ Ask for the change in a session. The AI edits the HTML source or `CLAUDE.md`.
- ✓ After `CLAUDE.md` changes, this guide's HTML and PDF are updated so all three stay in sync.
- ✓ Note PDFs are made on demand from the site; the originals from before the HTML rebuild are kept in `archive/`.

Local **Rendering**

```
.claude/skills/memory-dump/render.sh notes/<name>.html [out-dir]   # → <name>.pdf
```

Rules for AI assistants

- ✓ Read `CLAUDE.md` before creating or changing anything in the chalk book.
- ✓ Use the `memory-dump` skill to make notes, and `chalk-pastel.css` for every colour.
- ✓ Match the existing notes' structure and look exactly; open one as a reference if unsure.
- ✓ Never edit, rename or delete an existing note or archived PDF unless the user asks.
- ✓ Keep `CLAUDE.md`, this guide's HTML and its PDF in sync, and change them only when the user asks.
- ✓ Keep private data out *before* it is committed: GitHub may still serve a pushed commit after a force-push. If something slips through, tell the user; don't rewrite history without asking.
- ✓ Commit locally as needed, but push only when the user asks.